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May 24, 2026

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'Silent' water hike, deposit burden flayed

Tambaram residents challenge new water tariff as well as deposits and decry the lack of a consultation prior to the revision of the charges

PRINCE FREDERICK

In Tambaram City Municipal Corporation limits, residents are boiling over with resentment over what they call abnormal monthly water consumption charges and one-time deposits. They learnt nearly a week ago that they would have to fork out a deposit amount and monthly payment for water supply services based on the plinth area of their houses. The math has been worked out and the tariff slabs are available



Residents met the Tambaram Corporation Commissioner on May 18 and made their disenchantment known.

online. The new consumption charges are yet to take effect, having been put on hold, reportedly on the basis of residents' protest.

What has left a sour taste in their

mouth is the notification about the water supply deposits and increase in water consumption charges had been made in September 2025, immediately followed by a GO, but

they did not hear a chirp about it.

There was no consultation; no explanation. They should have pasted notices outside premises, says Sethu Madhavan P.G., senior social activist from AGS Colony in Chromepet.

D. Devaraj, secretary, Chromepet New Colony Residents Welfare Association notes that based on the new water consumption charges that would take effect, the increase would be 300 percent or more, for those with plinth area of 600 sq.ft or more. According to the revised water consumption charges, domestic consumers with a plinth area of 601 to 1200 sq.ft (which would account for a majority of consumers) will pay a monthly charge of ₹150, and a deposit of ₹10000. For those with a plinth area 1201 to 1800 sq.ft, ₹180 and ₹12,500. And the amounts rise along with the increase in plinth area. For domestic consumers with a plinth area of 600 sq.ft or less, it is ₹120 and ₹7500.

On April 15 this year, residents were on the warpath, when a hike accounting for a three-time increase in water consumption charges was introduced and it was rolled back before the day ended. The hike is being reintroduced, these activists note, underlining how the steep deposit amount would particularly affect senior citizens. On May 18, D. Devaraj and K. Subramanian from Chromepet New Colony Residents Welfare Association, Sethu Madhavan P.G. from AGS Colony, Chromepet and senior social activist Krishnamurti met Tambaram Corporation Commissioner S. Balachander and made their disenchantment known.

When these residents questioned him about the lack of prior information about the hike (as well as the absence of a consultation with residents), the Tambaram Corporation Commissioner reportedly said the information would be made available soon.



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An elusive honour for a freedom fighter

Activists seek to name Chromepet Knowledge Centre after Parali Su. Nellaiyapper; bust awaits official clearance for installation

T. ARVIND

A bust of freedom fighter Parali Su. Nellaiyapper, a close associate of Subramania Bharathi and V.O. Chidambaram Pillai, remains wrapped and awaiting installation at a memorial-cum-library premises in Chromepet, even as activists continue to seek official recognition for his contributions.

The premises, located in Tambaram Corporation's Ward 25, now functions as a Knowledge and Study Centre. Residents and activists have urged the civic body to attach the freedom fighter's name to the renovated facility and formally unveil his bust, which has been ready for installation since March this year.

Donated land

Parali Su. Nellaiyapper, a poet, philanthropist and freedom fighter, lived in Chromepet during the 1950s. In recognition of his services to the nation, the State government allotted him more than three acres of land in 1954. In 1968, he donated over two grounds of land for establishing a primary school for children from economically weaker sections.

The Parali Su. Nellaiyapper Municipal Primary School functioned for several years before becoming defunct by the late 1990s owing to a shortage of teachers and staff.

Over the years, the premises fell into disrepair, with the abandoned campus turning into a hub for anti-social activities. Residents and activists later initiated efforts to restore the property for public use.

Campaign for restoration

According to activist S. Meenakshisundaram, efforts to revive the school began in 1996 and gathered momentum after the forma-



tion of the Senior Citizen Welfare Association, Chromepet East, in 2015.

Association members conducted Independence Day and Republic Day celebrations at the premises and campaigned for its restoration. "Cases were filed against us claiming trespassing when we tried to maintain the premises and conduct public events," Meenakshisundaram said.

A major breakthrough came in 2022 when the then Pallavaram Municipality sanctioned ₹1 crore for redevelopment of the site. However, activists opposed proposals to convert the premises into a waste segregation facility or a veterinary clinic, insisting that the land should continue to serve educational purposes in keeping with the freedom fighter's vision.

Following sustained campaigns, including poster protests in 2023 over non-utilisation of funds, the Tambaram Corporation Knowledge and Study Centre was opened in January 2024.



Activist S. Meenakshisundaram points to the pedestal awaiting the installation of freedom fighter's bust at the Knowledge and Study Centre in Chromepet; and (below) Parali Su. Nellaiyapper. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Demand for recognition

Activists say the civic body is yet to accept their demand to rename the facility after Parali Su. Nellaiyapper.

"The Knowledge Centre was established on land donated by the freedom fighter. It is only appropriate that the centre bears his name," Meenakshisundaram said.

Efforts were also taken to install a bust of the freedom fighter at the premises. Former MLA E. Karunanidhi contributed around ₹1 lakh towards the in-

itiative, and the bust was sculpted in Mahabalipuram.

However, the installation has reportedly been delayed following disagreements over accommodating another leader's statue at the site. Though the pedestal was widened to house two busts, the second statue is yet to be completed, leaving Parali Su. Nellaiyapper's bust and portrait inside the centre.

Meenakshisundaram recently met Tambaram Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran and appealed for early clearance to unveil the bust.

Role in freedom movement

Parali Su. Nellaiyapper worked as an accountant in the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company founded by V.O. Chidambaram Pillai. Activists say he also played a key role in helping Subramania Bharathi relocate to Pudukcherry, then under French rule, to escape British persecution.

He is further remembered for assisting Bharathi's family in conducting the poet's last rites in Triplicane.

At present, nearly 100 students and youth use the Knowledge and Study Centre daily, including for NEET coaching classes. Activists are also planning to seek support from IIT-Madras for donating books to the centre.

Despite years of struggle to restore the premises, activists say their demand remains simple – that the centre be named after Parali Su. Nellaiyapper and that his bust be formally unveiled in honour of his contribution to society and the freedom movement.

An identity board finally for Ganapathypuram bus stop

P. KARTHIKEYAN

For years, buses completely skipped the Ganapathypuram stop on the 200-Foot Radial Road, despite it being listed as a stop on the official app of the Metropolitan Transport Corporation.

Following persistent citizen complaints, an MTC official recently inspected the site, leading to the installation of a permanent metal board.

However, some work is still pending. The stop remains missing from bus conductors' Electronic Ticketing Machines (ETMs).

Drivers also remain unaware of the new boarding point and routinely speed past. I request the MTC to urgently update its ETMs software and issue official halting circulars to the respective depots.

Additionally, commuters need a corresponding MTC board on the opposite side of the highway.

Furthermore, with vehicles speeding near the new median opening, crossing this highway is fraught with risk. The Tamil Nadu State Highways Department and Traffic Police must establish a safe pedestrian crossing at this location.

I also urge the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to construct a proper bus shelter, as this stop is the only lifeline for last-mile connectivity in our neighborhood.

P. Karthikeyan is a resident of Ganapathypuram, Chromepet



The signboard mentioning the stop. Photo: Special Arrangement

'Shift TASMAL outlet out of Sembakkam'



The liquor outlet on Nanmangalam - Hastinapuram Link Road in Sembakkam; and a canal overrun with waste. Photo: Special Arrangement

V SAKUNTHALA

The presence of a TASMAL outlet in Sembakkam on Nanmangalam-Hastinapuram Link Road has a serious consequence. This shop is roughly 500 metres from Zion School in Sembakkam. The road's narrow width makes it difficult for schoolchildren to cross it, especially in the evenings when the shop is open. We request that this concern be taken into account and the outlet be relocated.

V. Sakunthala is a resident of Sembakkam

Concerns over Sembakkam lake reiterated

In a petition submitted to Chengalpattu Collector S. Malathi Helen, residents of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar have sought removal of encroachments at the waterbody and an end to sewage inflow



M. Ravi, secretary of the Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents Association, seen with S. Malathi Helen, Chengalpattu District Collector. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

TS ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar in Chitlapakkam have submitted a petition to the Chengalpattu District Collector, S. Malathi Helen, to take action to save Sembakkam Lake.

The Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents Association has been fighting for more than

two decades to save the waterbody asking for removal of structures in the lake area and to stop sewage discharge. Despite notices given to encroachers to vacate, no action has been taken. An encroachment, removed years ago, has come up again, says M. Ravi, secretary of the association.

M. Ravi stated to the Col-

lector that a new structure has come up in the lake area and has been provided with a power connection.

Create a parking lot

There is a need to create an authorised two-wheeler parking stand at Tambaram Sanatorium East as vast tracts of land belonging to Central and State Governments are available, say residents. This would help many commuters as currently, the parking charges at private parking lots are higher than the train ticket prices, Ravi added. On First Main Road in the locality, an encroachment has emerged, reducing road space. The road facilitates connectivity to interior stretches in the locality including a school. The encroachment should be removed as it adds to the traffic congestion on the stretch.

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In Nanmangalam, where a lake and a reserve forest are located cheek by jowl, the view may not be picture-perfect, being marred by garbage dumping and sewage inflow. But the picture is eye-catching as well, thanks to people's participation in improving conditions and its wildlife. Around International Day for Biological Diversity (May 22), a close look at the patch and its people

Between a lake and a forest

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

The health of a lake is directly proportional to the acts of positive reciprocity it receives from the people it serves. Its health is also predicated on the pride it instils in those people. The Nanmangalam lake is presented with a mixed bag. It is subjected to abuse by those in a position of stewardship towards it, but it also has two groups of people that make sure it stays in the news, its charms being extolled and its blights highlighted. And these groups vary in their composition, but have found a point of intersection where goals unite into something composite: preserving and cherishing the Nanmangalam lake.

Kumaresan Chandrabose is

part of the local residents group, largely drawn from Sembakkam, Nanmangalam and Hastinapuram that has been documenting the biodiversity of the lake as well as the Nanmangalam Reserve forest that overlooks it, actually the rim of the forest. Through photography and videography, he has documented a wide range of resident and migratory species around the lake, as have most other members of this hyperlocal naturalist group. People outside this group also join nature walks.

According to Kumaresan, bird-watching has changed the way people view the lake.

The list of birds recorded at Nanmangalam is extensive. Among them are the Chestnut-winged Cuckoo, Asian Paradise

Flycatcher, Yellow Bittern, Painted Snipe, Black Bittern, Watercock, Long-toed Stint and Oriental Magpie Robin. Darters are also regularly spotted across the lake.

One species that particularly stands out is the Chestnut-winged Cuckoo, a migratory bird that has wintered in Nanmangalam as its winter destination.

Kumaresan also described the

Beauty and squalor coexist. (Clockwise from top) An Oriental magpie robin in a pile of garbage; the dumping site; and a Painted snipe and a plastic discard.

PHOTOS: KUMARESAN CHANDRABOSE & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Watercock as one of the more unusual birds found within Chennai Metropolitan area. Yellow Bittern nesting sites and Darter breeding activity have also been observed around the wetland. Interestingly, some migratory birds move into nearby residential areas as well. The Blue-throated Blue Flycatcher, for instance, has been repeatedly spotted near

a temple inside a nearby apartment complex.

Beyond birds, he tracks butterflies and odonates around the lake, several of which have become harder to find.

A butterfly called the Joker, which depends on a native host plant called *Taglia*, locally known as Sendatti, is becoming scarce around the lake. Though the plant is often removed because it causes skin irritation, Kumaresan says it plays an important ecological role.

"In the name of beautification, many of these native bushes are being removed," he says.

Waste dumping is another negative factor.

No time to 'waste'

Over time, worsening environmental damage pushed a group of residents and volunteers to come together under the "Saving Nanmangalam Lake" initiative, a citizen-led movement launched in June 2024 to protect the lake and create awareness about its ecological importance.

Among those leading these efforts are Jayapriya Ramanathan and R. Sathya, both residents of Sembakkam who have been actively involved in cleanup drives and awareness campaigns around the lake. According to organisers, untreated sewage inflow, encroachments, garbage dumping, and poor waste management remain some of the biggest threats

facing the ecosystem today.

Another challenge, according to the organisers, is the lake's fragmented administration. Portions of the lake fall within the limits of different local civic bodies (including the Tambaram Corporation), making coordinated restoration efforts challenging. "All the departments need to work together collectively," says Jayapriya, stressing that both the lake and adjoining reserve

forest require integrated protection measures.

A major concern is the garbage transit point established between the reserve forest and the lake by a panchayat. The site functions as a dumping and transportation area for municipal waste.

"We have seen cattle consuming plastic waste," says Sathya, adding that birds and other animals are also likely being affected by the pollution. This scenario makes biomagnification real.

Sathya also points out untreated sewage continues entering the waterbody.

In response, the initiative has focused heavily on community participation. Volunteers organise cleanup drives, awareness

campaigns, walkathons, meetings with officials, and waste segregation programmes. Residents are encouraged to reduce plastic usage, segregate waste properly and switch to cloth or jute bags.

A large awareness walkathon conducted earlier this year reportedly saw participation from nearly 600 volunteers.

Organisers say these efforts have started making a visible difference. In some stretches, garbage dumping has reduced, warning boards have been installed, and partial fencing work has been completed along the South Bund Road.

"Initially, many people believed nothing would change," Jayapriya says. "Gradually, public participation and awareness began to increase."

Though residents joined the initiative at different stages, the core volunteer group now consists of around 15 active members working consistently on the ground. Elderly residents who are unable to participate physically contribute through paperwork and coordination with government departments.

The movement has also expanded beyond the lake. Organisers recently formed the Vanam and Neer Foundation to support conservation efforts involving both the wetland and the Nanmangalam Reserve Forest.

Still, challenges remain. Waste often reappears after cleanup drives, and urban pressure around the lake continues to intensify. Conservation efforts, they say, cannot depend on volunteers alone.



Pallavaram MLA gets a shopping list of demands from social activist



V. Santhanam with Pallavaram MLA J. Kamatchi.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

V. Santhanam, a veteran social activist, met newly elected MLA J. Kamatchi on May 20 to highlight issues that require immediate attention.

Flooding on GST Road

“It has been years since the State Highways Department requested the Southern Railway to widen the culverts beneath the railway tracks in Chromepet and Pallavaram regions to prevent flooding on GST Road. However, to date, there is no sign of work despite the Department's reminders to Southern Railway.

“The culverts along the tracks are not wide enough to drain the water. As a result, flooding occurs on GST Road. This is a perennial problem during rains,” said Santhanam.

Restoring waterbodies

Santhanam urged the MLA ensure water hyacinth is removed from Veeraraghavan Eri in Tambaram Sanatorium and Nemilichery Eri to allow rainwater to be stored. Failure to do so could result in flooding in Chromepet, Tambaram Sanatorium and Hasthinapuram. “The Water Resources Department should expedite the restoration of Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, noting that the work is currently proceeding at a snail's pace. The MLA assured Santhanam that the issues would be addressed and requested reasonable time to look into the issues and take appropriate action.

PNB opens branch in Perungalathur



Pawan Singh, zonal manager for Chennai, inaugurating the branch

Punjab National Bank opened its 103rd branch with an ATM at New Perungalathur. Pawan Singh, zonal manager for Chennai, inaugurated the branch at Shraddha Arcade, Srinivasa Nagar, Kalaignar Nedunchalai, New Perungalathur.

The branch is equipped with modern banking infrastructure and digital facilities designed to

deliver efficient, secure, and customer-centric services. The ATM will provide the local community with a convenient 24/7 banking access, said a release. Lalmohan Satapathy, circle head, Chennai; N. Syed Anwar Theen and Dharendra Kumar Shashi, deputy circle heads; and Jana Avinash, branch head, were present.

Quiz for middle-school students

Chennai-based KSA Trust is inviting school teams for the second edition of ‘Quiz Champions of Chennai - 2026’.

Curated by expert quiz masters, this event is designed to educate and engage middle-school students by sharing champion stories and diverse areas of knowledge.

The 2025 event had 28 schools and 1,550 students participating in it. Winners received certificates, gift vouchers, and a plaque for their school.

Founded by the 30-year-old Chennai-based Chartered Accounting firm Kalyanasundaram

Associates, since 2013 KSA Trust has been running its annual ‘Champions of Chennai Awards’, where it honour individuals and organisations in Chennai who have made remarkable contributions across fields such as arts, education, healthcare, enterprise, social initiative, science, and sports. These are people who serve selflessly, often without recognition, yet profoundly impact our community, said a release.

To learn more, please visit: www.championsofchennai.org

For any questions regarding the quiz, email rao@championsofchennai.org or call 98411 16216.

Advanced robotic surgery performed



The team of surgeons and anesthetists. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A robotic nephrectomy was performed on a three-year-old child using the SSI Mantra 3, a robotic surgical platform at Murugan Hospital, Kilpauk. The surgery was led by Dr. Raghu M, a paediatric surgeon, along with assistant surgeon Dr. Sabari, and supported by SSI Mantra robotic technician Vishal Pandian. The anesthesia team was headed by Dr. Karthikeyan.

According to a press release, the child had been

suffering from recurrent urinary tract infections due to a rare congenital urological abnormality – a non-functioning left kidney associated with a grossly dilated and tortuous ectopic ureter draining into the vagina.

Using robotic-assisted minimally invasive surgery, the diseased kidney and abnormal ureter were removed through tiny incisions. The procedure was completed successfully in approximately one hour,

with minimal blood loss and excellent intraoperative stability, the release added.

Dr. Raghu said, “Robotic technology is gradually transforming the way complex pediatric surgical procedures are performed. In young children, precision becomes extremely important due to limited working space and delicate anatomical structures.”

The hospital is located at Kilpauk Garden Road. Phone: 044 4644 8989.

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‘Desilting exercise dragging on’

DHIVYA SARAVANAN

Residents of Subrayanagar near Thiruneermalai in Chromepet have raised serious concerns over the ongoing desilting and land development activities at Thiruneermalai Lake.

According to local residents, nearly half of the lake park area has



Work under way at Thiruneermalai Lake.
Photos: Dhivya Saravanan

been under construction for the past four months as part of the desilting procedure.

People in the area have also alleged that illegal sand extraction took place during February, following which government authorities reportedly took action based on complaints from local residents.

Locals further stated that the condition of the lake is affecting groundwater levels in the surrounding neighbourhoods. Many households are reportedly dependent on borewells due to severe water shortage, and residents say even groundwater is becoming unavailable in several areas.

Senior residents of the locality said that if the lake is properly restored, maintained, and protected, it could significantly improve groundwater recharge and help ensure regular water supply to nearby homes, as it did in earlier years

Satsang programme in Hasthinapuram

Sri Krishna Sweets and Sri Vittal Rukmani Samasthanam, Govindapuram, is organising a ‘Pravah’ with Sriji, on May 24, at Sri Ram Ganesh Mahal, Rajendra Prasad Road, Raghav Nagar, Hasthinapuram, at 6.15 p. m..

Repair Cafe workshop

Repair Cafe Chennai will be conducting its next electrical workshop in Thoraipakkam on May 30; 10 a.m. to 1 p.m.

Open to all, the session will equip one to pick up hands-on skills. Check out their insta page @repaircafe.tiruandchennai to know about the workshop.

Session on organic farming

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is organising a culinary workshop on making soups on May 27.

For details, call 044 - 29530048



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